

## RINGMASTER OF RUIN

[Cold Open]

[Warped calliope loop grinds up out of tune. Distant thunder rolls like a drumroll. Rain hisses on a canvas tent. A Ringmaster's voice arrives low and velvet, amused by everything.]

[Spoken, Villain Voice, Unhurried]

"Ladies... gentlemen... and every last one of you who swore you'd never run away and join the circus..."

"Too late."

"You already did."

"The moment life knocked you flat and you got back up laughing —"

"— that's when you signed the contract."

(Heh heh heh...) (Lights up.) (Let 'em in.)

## RINGMASTER OF RUIN!

[Intro]

[Calliope drifts under rolling thunder. Sliding 808s creep in beneath tent-canvas snare hits. Ringmaster savors the calm before chaos.]

(Ayy...) (Watch close.) (Here we go.)

[Sung, Rubato/Free Time, Sweetly Sinister]

step right up and lose your shadow

leave it hangin' at the door

everybody wants the encore

nobody wants to rehearse the fall

RINGMASTER OF RUIN! (Hey now!)

[Verse 1]

[Voice smug, theatrical, treating disaster like showbiz]

I'M the LION and the TAMER in the SAME damn CAGE (facts)

BUILT my WHOLE circus OUT of ASH and RAGE (burn)

GOT a TIGHTROPE made of PROMISES nobody KEPT (haha)

WALK it EVERY night and NEVER once misSTEP (whoa)

TENT full of MIRRORS, every ONE of 'em CRACKED (real)

STILL find a VERSION of me that LOOKS intact (facts)

RINGLEADER of the WRECKAGE, conDUCTOR of the FALL

I make the THUNDER clap on CUE like it's my CALL (boom)

TRAINED all my DEMONS to JUGGLE with FIRE (what?)

NOW they PERFORM every NIGHT for the CHOIR (run it)  
STEP through the CURTAIN, the STORM is the SHOW  
when LIFE says, "SIT down..."

I put on the SHOW!

[Pre-Chorus]  
[Voice drops to a hush, patient and certain, before the chant detonates]

[Sung, Sustained Notes, Cold and Calm]  
can't cage a hurricane  
can't tame the tide  
can't spook a soul  
who already ran with the ringmaster's pride

[Spoken, Building, Grinning]  
hush now...  
watch close...  
applaud...

RINGMASTER OF RUIN!

[Chorus]  
[Full carnival crew answers every line — booming, gleeful, unhinged]

[Sung, Belted, Full Gang Vocal, Big Top Chaos]  
RINGMASTER OF RUIN! (Step right up!)

when the tent starts burnin'  
we call it the finale! (Burn it!)

when the crowd starts screamin'  
we call that an encore! (Encore!)

top hat  
crooked grin  
sawdust on my chin

if the devil's in the front row  
tell him, "welcome home!"

RINGMASTER OF RUIN! (Woo!)

crack the whip  
cue the band  
turn the wreckage  
into wonderland

storms take bows

curtains don't

so...

RINGMASTER OF RUIN!

[Verse 2]

[Half-confession, half-monologue — the Ringmaster grows fonder of his own chaos]

I SOLD tickets to my OWN damn DOWNFALL (facts)  
PACKED the house, they LOVED the CURTAIN call (grow)  
EVERYbody CLAPS for the LION till it ROARS  
then they REMEMBER why they LOCKED the cage DOORS (talk)

I don't CHASE applause  
I FEED the silence  
EVERY empty SEAT just MEANS more DEFIANCE  
turned my WORST reviews into a HEADLINE dance (yeah)

the ELEPHANTS in the ROOM learned how to TAP-dance too  
STOMPIN' out a RHYTHM that the CRITICS never KNEW (flow)

BROKEN spotlight STILL finds a WAY to SHINE (boom)  
BURNED-down BIG top STILL draws a LINE (run it)

let the CYNICS sit  
in the CHEAP back ROW  
funny how the WRECKAGE  
STILL puts on a SHOW

EVERY fall's a BIT  
EVERY flop's a BEAT  
PRESSURE built the BIG top  
now we OWN the STREET

so if the crowd goes quiet...

fine by me...

encore anyway.

RINGMASTER OF RUIN!

[Bridge]

[Music strips to sub-bass, warped music box, single spotlight hum. Ringmaster turns intimate, almost tender.]

[Spoken/Sung Hybrid, Hypnotic, Quietly Sincere]  
every act needs a villain  
every villain needs a crowd

find the part of you  
that isn't scared out loud

the storm ain't your enemy...

it's your opening number

every burned-down tent...

still smells like summer

[Final Chorus]

[Full theatrical power — Ringmaster laughing between lines, gang chants building into a joyful riot]

[Sung, Belted, Full Gang Vocal, Wall of Sound, Triumphant]

RINGMASTER OF RUIN! (One more time!)

thunder's the drumline  
lightning's the spotlight  
chaos keeps encore-in'  
every single night

crooked smile  
steady hands  
broken clocks  
still lead the band

if tonight burns the tent down

bow anyway

take your bow

stand back up

again

RINGMASTER OF RUIN!  
RINGMASTER OF RUIN!  
RINGMASTER OF RUIN!

[Outro]

[Calliope winds down. Thunder rolls off into silence. Ringmaster takes his final bow.]

[Spoken, Villain Voice, Warm and Wicked, Fading]

"No net."

"No safety wire."

"No apology."

"Just sawdust..."

"...smoke..."

"...and a man who learned to love the fall."

"Same time tomorrow?"

RINGMASTER OF RUIN! (Fade.)